

Playing games

Throughout history, humans have devised ways to entertain themselves using objects such as cards, counters, boards, and dice. Over millennia these have evolved into the games we know today, from traditional sets with simple rules and basic pieces, all the way to modern electronic consoles with advanced technology and lifelike interactive graphics.

Pit and pebble game

Mancala



Strategy game

Chess

Where Asia
When c. 600 CE

Many countries claim to have invented chess but one forerunner of the game appeared in India in the 7th century. Over the centuries chess has evolved and spread across the globe, becoming one of the most popular strategy games. It is played with two players who take turns to move 16 pieces to attack each other's king. The aim is to trap the king into checkmate, so that it cannot move to safety.



Card game

Chinese playing cards

Where China
When 9th century CE

The earliest known playing cards are believed to have originated in China during the Tang Dynasty (see pp.66–67), though how games with these cards were played is not known today. The modern pack of 52 playing cards, with hearts, spades, diamonds, and clubs, developed much later, in France during the 15th century.



Decorative cards were made of flexible cardboard.

Word game

Crossword

Where US
When 1913

The first crossword puzzle was published in the Sunday supplement of the *New York World* newspaper. A series of written clues help the player complete a grid of horizontal and vertical missing words. Crosswords are not only entertaining, but also expand vocabulary and aid brain development.

